



Phishing Awareness Training

A comprehensive cybersecurity awareness module for students, employees, and non-technical users — built to help you recognise, avoid, and report phishing attacks before they cause harm.

CODEALPHA CYBERSECURITY INTERNSHIP — TASK 2

What We'll Cover

Your Training Roadmap

01

Understanding Phishing

What it is, who attackers target, and why it works

02

Types & Tactics

Email, spear, smishing, vishing, social engineering

03

Spotting the Signs

Anatomy of a phishing email, fake sites, URL spoofing

04

Defence & Response

MFA, password hygiene, reporting, safe browsing

05

Quiz & Assessment

Test your knowledge with scenario-based challenges

What Is Phishing?

Phishing is a **social engineering attack** where criminals impersonate trusted entities — banks, employers, tech companies — to trick victims into revealing sensitive information or clicking malicious links.

The Hook

A convincing message designed to trigger urgency or trust

The Trap

A fake link, attachment, or login page that steals data

The Damage

Stolen credentials, financial loss, or malware infection



What Attackers Are After



High-Value Targets

→ Login Credentials

Username and passwords to email, banking, and corporate systems

→ Financial Data

Credit card numbers, bank account details, PayPal access

→ Personal Identity

National IDs, dates of birth, and answers to security questions

→ Corporate Access

VPN credentials, internal systems, and confidential business data

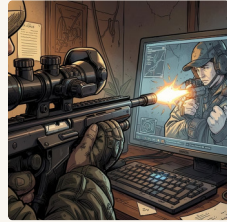
Chapter 1 — Attack Types

The Phishing Family Tree



Email Phishing

Bulk, untargeted emails impersonating brands like PayPal, Microsoft, or your bank.



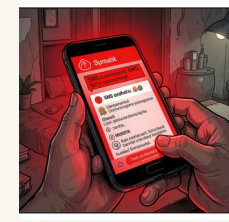
Spear Phishing

Highly personalised attacks using your name, job title, or company details for credibility.



Whaling

Spear phishing aimed at C-suite executives — CEOs, CFOs — for maximum organisational impact.



Smishing & Vishing

SMS-based (smishing) and voice call-based (vishing) attacks impersonating banks or tech support.

Dissecting a Phishing Email

A Realistic Example — Fake PayPal Alert

❌ **From:** security-alert@paypa1-support.com
Subject: ⚠️ Unusual Activity — Verify Your Account Now

"Dear Valued Customer, we detected suspicious activity on your PayPal account. Your account will be **suspended in 24 hours** unless you verify your identity immediately. [Click here to secure your account.](#)"

This email hits every psychological trigger: urgency, fear, and authority impersonation.

Red Flags Decoded

🚩 Spoofed Sender

paypa1-support.com — note the number "1" replacing the letter "l"

🚩 Urgency Language

"24 hours", "suspended" — designed to override rational thinking

🚩 Generic Greeting

"Dear Valued Customer" — real PayPal uses your actual name

🚩 Suspicious Link

Always hover before clicking — the URL will never match paypal.com

Chapter 3 — Social Engineering

The Psychology Behind the Attack

Phishing succeeds not through technical skill alone — it exploits **human psychology**. Attackers are trained manipulators.



Urgency & Scarcity

"Act now or lose access" — time pressure shuts down critical thinking and forces hasty decisions.



Authority

Impersonating your IT department, the CEO, or a government agency to demand compliance.



Greed & Fear

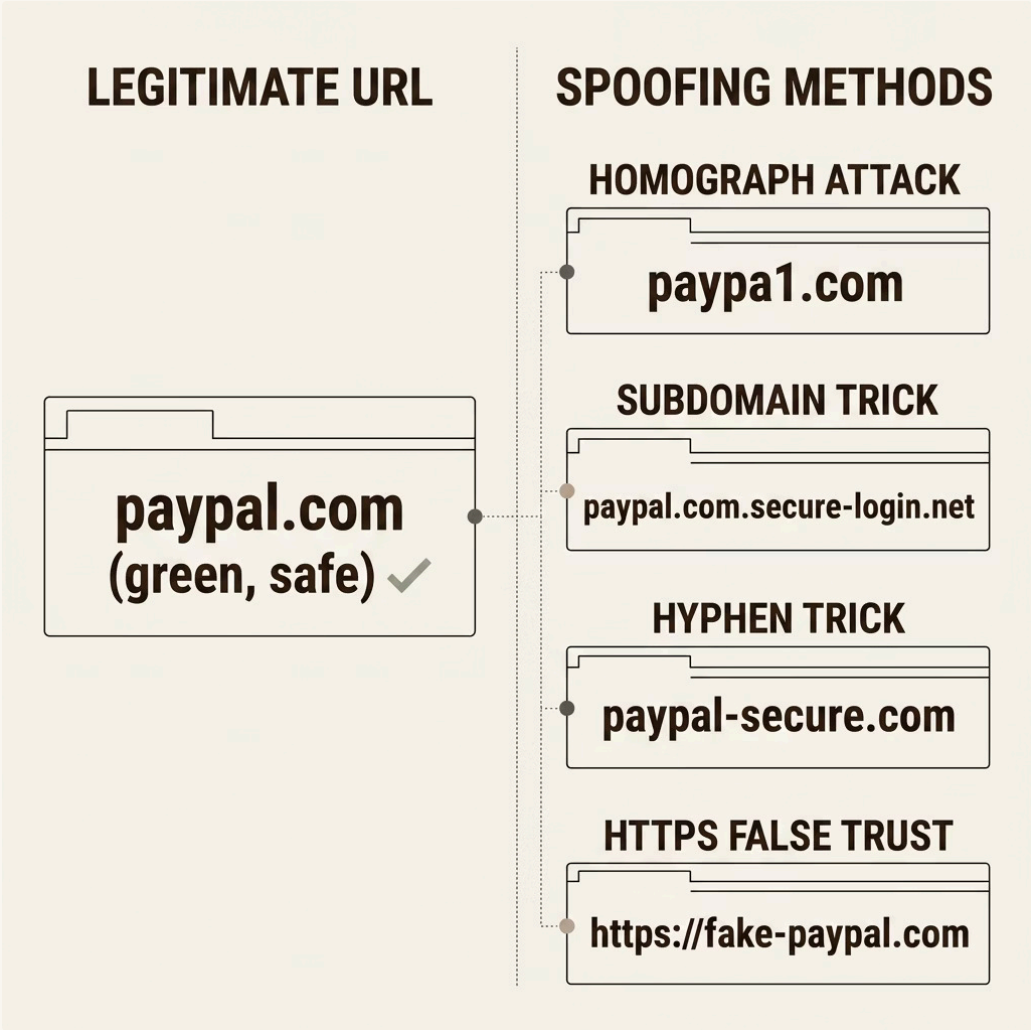
"You've won a prize" or "Your account is hacked" — both emotions bypass logical reasoning.



Familiarity & Trust

Using your name, company logo, or referencing a colleague to build false credibility.

Fake Websites & URL Spoofing



The Golden Rules of URL Safety

- 1 Always hover before you click**
The status bar shows the real destination URL — check it every time
- 2 HTTPS ≠ Safe**
A padlock only means the connection is encrypted — not that the site is legitimate
- 3 Check the root domain**
The real domain is always the last part before .com/.org — everything else is a subdomain



Chapter 5 — Your Defence

Prevention Best Practices



Enable MFA Everywhere

Multi-factor authentication blocks 99.9% of automated credential attacks, even if your password is stolen.



Use a Password Manager

Generate unique, complex passwords for every account. Never reuse passwords across services.



Verify Before You Click

When in doubt, navigate directly to the website. Never click links in unsolicited emails or SMS.



Report Suspicious Emails

Use your email client's "Report Phishing" button. Reporting protects your entire organisation.

Final Assessment

Test Your Knowledge

Identify the correct answer for each scenario below.

1

Q1 — Sender Verification

You receive an email from support@micros0ft-help.com asking you to reset your password. What should you do?

✔ **Answer:** Do not click. Navigate directly to microsoft.com and check your account. Report the email as phishing.

2

Q2 — URL Safety

A site shows a padlock and starts with HTTPS. A colleague says it's definitely safe. Are they correct?

✔ **Answer:** No. HTTPS only encrypts data in transit. The site can still be a malicious fake. Always verify the root domain.

3

Q3 — Urgency Tactic

An SMS claims your bank account is locked and gives you 2 hours to click a link. What is happening?

✔ **Answer:** This is a smishing attack. Banks never lock accounts via SMS links. Call your bank directly using the number on their official website.

✔ 🎓 **Training Complete!** You are now equipped to identify and defend against phishing. Stay vigilant — when something feels wrong, trust your instincts and verify through official channels.